

Texas Mineral Rights Ownership

Courthouse Records & API Feasibility

Prepared for: Location Intelligence pilot (DFW counties)

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Scope: Whether Texas county courthouses expose mineral ownership via API, and what alternatives exist for tracking ownership programmatically.

Executive Summary

Texas has no statewide mineral ownership database. Ownership is established by recorded instruments filed with the County Clerk in the county where the minerals are located. Each of the 254 counties maintains its own index; systems vary (GovOS Public Search, Tyler Technologies, Kofile, legacy in-house).

Finding: None of the five DFW pilot county clerk portals expose a public developer API for mineral deed or lease searches. GovOS (used by Dallas, Collin, Denton, Tarrant) is a browser-only search portal. Rockwall uses Tyler Host with the same limitation. Tarrant additionally offers paid bulk data by contacting the clerk (817-884-1069) - not a REST API.

Practical paths for programmatic ownership tracking:

1. Paid aggregators (TexasFile, Enverus Courthouse, Echo Prime) with bulk export or API.
2. County appraisal district mineral rolls (producing interests only, not full title).
3. Custom courthouse index scrapers (legally risky; many counties prohibit automated access).
4. Manual title research by landmen for chain-of-title on specific tracts.

Approach	Ownership depth	API?	Cost	DFW pilot fit
County Clerk OPR index	Full title chain	No public API	Free search / paid copies	High value, hard to automate
Appraisal District mineral roll	Producing owners only	No unified API	Free CAD sites	Good for active wells
TexasFile mineral data	Producing + clerk index	No public API*	\$0.25/search; bulk CSV	Best commercial starting point
Enverus Courthouse	Indexed clerk docs	Enterprise	Paid subscription	Title shops / land departments
Echo Prime / EPT	Deeds + title chains	REST API (paid)	\$99-299/mo	Programmatic if budget allows
RRC well/API data	Activity not ownership	Bulk only	Free	Already partial in pilot
BLM MLRS	Federal leases only	ArcGIS REST	Free	Working in pilot (not private ownership)

*TexasFile offers bulk mineral rolls (CSV) and clerk record downloads; API access is not advertised publicly.

1. How Texas Records Mineral Ownership

Mineral rights can be severed from surface estate. Ownership changes are proven by recorded documents at the County Clerk:

- Mineral Deed / Mineral and Royalty Deed (conveys mineral interest)
- Oil and Gas Lease (does not transfer ownership; grants development rights)
- Assignment (transfers lease or royalty interest)
- Release / Partial Release
- Probate / Affidavit of Heirship / Executor's Deed (inheritance)
- Division Order (operator acknowledgment of decimal interest - often not recorded)

Title research requires a chain of title: stepping backward grantee-to-grantor through deeds, reading each instrument for mineral reservations (e.g., 'Grantor reserves all oil, gas, and other minerals'). Gaps in the chain create title defects. This is why ownership is courthouse-centric, not parcel-GIS-centric.

Sample courthouse index record (illustrative - Dallas County OPR)

doc_number	recorded_date	doc_type	grantor	grantee
20240123456	03/15/2024	MINERAL DEED	SMITH, JOHN A	SMITH FAMILY TRUST
20230891234	11/02/2023	OIL & GAS LEASE	JONES RANCH LLC	DEVON ENERGY PROD CO
20220567890	06/18/2022	ASSIGNMENT O&G LEASE	DEVON ENERGY PROD CO	PIONEER NATURAL RES
20190765432	09/30/2019	WARRANTY DEED	BROWN, MARY E	BROWN HOLDINGS LP

(reservation: 1/2 minerals reserved by grantor)

Source pattern: search Dallas County Official Public Records at dallas.tx.publicsearch.us by grantor, grantee, document type, or legal description. Similar indexes exist in other pilot counties.

Sample mineral deed excerpt (illustrative body text)

MINERAL AND ROYALTY DEED
 KNOW ALL MEN BY THESE PRESENTS: That Grantor, John A. Smith, of Dallas County, Texas,
 for consideration paid, grants, sells, and conveys unto Grantee, Smith Family Trust,
 an undivided 25% of all oil, gas, and other minerals in and under the following described
 property in Dallas County, Texas:
 Abstract 1234, Survey J. Smith, 40.00 acres, more or less
 TO HAVE AND TO HOLD ... together with all rights incident to ownership of such minerals.
 Executed: March 10, 2024. Recorded: Instrument 20240123456, Dallas County Clerk.

2. DFW Pilot County Courthouse Assessment

County	Clerk portal	Vendor	Online index start	API access
Dallas (48113)	dallas.tx.publicsearch.us	GovOS	1964	No public API
Tarrant (48439)	tarrant.tx.publicsearch.us	GovOS	1943	No API; bulk data by request
Collin (48085)	collin.tx.publicsearch.us	GovOS	1845	No public API
Denton (48121)	denton.tx.publicsearch.us	GovOS	1854	No public API
Rockwall (48397)	rockwalltx-web.tylerhost.net	Tyler	1848	No public API

All five counties offer free index search (grantor/grantee, doc type, legal description, OCR full text where enabled). Document images are free (watermarked) or paid (certified). None publish OpenAPI/Socrata endpoints for clerk records. GovOS documentation confirms the product is a web search engine, not an integrator API platform.

Tarrant County bulk data note

Tarrant County Clerk advertises Bulk Data Payments via the official records payment portal (Department: Central Library-Bulk Data). This is a clerk-mediated data purchase, not a developer API. Contact: 817-884-1069 after payment.

TexasFile coverage (commercial mirror - all 5 pilot counties)

County	Clerk index via TexasFile	Mineral roll via TexasFile
Dallas	01/01/1969 - present	Producing interests; bulk CSV available
Tarrant	01/01/1943 - present	Producing interests; bulk CSV available
Collin	02/11/1845 - present	Producing interests; bulk CSV available
Denton	05/12/1854 - present	Producing interests; bulk CSV available
Rockwall	10/20/1848 - present	Producing interests; bulk CSV available

3. Appraisal District Mineral Rolls (Secondary Source)

Texas appraisal districts separately assess producing mineral interests for property tax. If minerals are in production, the CAD roll lists owner name, operator, lease, interest type (royalty, working, override), and decimal interest. This confirms producing ownership but does NOT replace courthouse title work for non-producing or severed minerals.

County	Appraisal District	Website	Mineral roll access
Dallas	Dallas CAD	dallascad.org	Property search; mineral accounts in roll
Tarrant	Tarrant Appraisal District	tad.org	Property search + interactive maps
Collin	Collin CAD	collincad.org	Property search
Denton	Denton CAD	dentoncad.com	Property search
Rockwall	Rockwall CAD	rockwallcad.com	Property search

Sample appraisal district mineral roll row (illustrative)

owner_name	operator	lease_name	interest	decimal_interest	rrc_lease_id
SMITH, JOHN A	DEVON ENERGY	SMITH UNIT	R	0.12500000	123456
JONES FAMILY TR	PIONEER NATURAL	JONES ESTATE	R	0.06250000	234567
BROWN HOLDINGS LP	RANGE RESOURCES	BROWN A	W	0.25000000	345678

TexasFile repackages CAD mineral rolls into searchable and bulk CSV products (\$0.25/search or county bulk purchase). Sample bulk roll formats are published for Karnes and Ward counties on texasfile.com/minerals/.

4. What Our Pilot Already Has (Not Ownership)

The location-intelligence pipeline currently includes mineral-adjacent data, not ownership:

Source	File	What it is	Ownership?
BLM MLRS	data/raw/blm_leases.csv	Federal O&G lease count	No - federal leases
Texas RRC	data/raw/rrc_wells.csv	Well catalog (empty)	No - well activity
County dashboard	exports/county_dashboard	blm_lease_count/acres	Proxy only

BLM pilot results (July 2026): Dallas 97 leases / 111,829 ac; Tarrant 321 / 152,902 ac. These are federal lease polygons in county bounding boxes, not private mineral title.

5. Recommended Path for Ownership Tracking

Tier A - Fastest programmatic start (paid):

- TexasFile bulk mineral rolls for pilot counties (CSV with owner, operator, lease, interest).
- TexasFile clerk index for mineral deed / lease instrument searches by grantor-grantee.

Tier B - Enterprise title automation (paid):

- Enverus Courthouse (350M+ land records, 150 TX counties with PDF docs).
- Echo Prime Title Intelligence REST API (98 TX counties, chain-of-title pipeline).

Tier C - Build in-house (high effort):

- Negotiate bulk data agreement with Dallas/Tarrant clerk offices.
- Landman workflow on GovOS portals for tract-specific chain of title.
- Join courthouse owners to RRC lease IDs and BLM federal leases for complete picture.

Tier D - Not sufficient alone:

- RRC API/well data, BLM MLRS, or surface parcel GIS (TAD parcels show surface owner only).

Sample integration target schema (ownership layer)

county_fips	tract_key	owner_name	interest_type	decimal_interest	source
48113	A-1234-SUR-JSM	SMITH FAMILY TR	royalty	0.125	CAD roll / TXFile
48113	A-1234-SUR-JSM	SMITH FAMILY TR	mineral fee	0.250	Clerk mineral deed
48113	A-1234-SUR-JSM	DEVON ENERGY	leasehold	N/A	Clerk O&G lease

6. Legal & Operational Caveats

- Texas Property Code and clerk policies may redact personal information (GovOS HB 4350 redactions in Collin).
- RRC prohibits automated scraping of interactive query systems.
- Courthouse indexes are not warranties of title; gaps require professional examination.
- Commercial use of Zillow/TexasFile data may have attribution and redistribution limits.

- Inherited minerals often span multiple counties; each requires separate clerk searches.

Sources Consulted

Dallas County Clerk - dallas.tx.publicsearch.us

Tarrant County Clerk - tarrant.tx.publicsearch.us; tarrantcountytexas.gov/county-clerk/real-estate-records

Collin County Clerk - collin.tx.publicsearch.us

Denton County Clerk - denton.tx.publicsearch.us

Rockwall County Clerk - rockwalltx-web.tylerhost.net/web/

TexasFile coverage - texasfile.com/coverage/; texasfile.com/minerals/

GovOS Public Records - govos.com

Texas RRC - rrc.texas.gov/resource-center/research

BLM MLRS - gis.blm.gov

Pilot pipeline - [location-intelligence data/raw/blm_leases.csv](#)